

Advance Scout — Aaron Nola (RHP) vs the Los Angeles Dodgers

Philadelphia vs Los Angeles · Citizens Bank Park · 2026-07-22 · home start · third extension of the Nola advance file (UC8 → UC15 → UC26)

Prepared for: manager / pitching coaches & analysts / catcher (Realmuto or Marchan) / Nola — advance meeting
Throws: R · **Arsenal:** 6 pitches (Knuckle Curve, Sinker, 4-Seam, Cutter, Changeup, Slider) **Governance:** Use Case #26 (uc-pps-021). Every rate KPI is **inherited verbatim** from the locked UC8 → UC11 → UC15 line (get_stats/nresults, whiff, chase, putaway, FPSR, hard-hit) plus the **UC8 glossary-approved trio** (edge rate, out-of-zone called-strike rate, AIR/GB rate). **No new rate KPIs.** Recomputed live off `phils_2015..2026`, fresh through Nola's last start **2026-07-16**. Supersedes `dp_uc15`'s season figures (earlier cache).

△ **Read this first — data window & sample sizes.** - **Career log** = `data/phillies/phils_2015..2026.parquet`, entity-locked to **MLBAM 605400** (not Nolan Hoffman 676510), regular season only, deduped. Cache fresh through **2026-07-16** — Nola's most recent start (he starts tonight on 6 days' rest). - **Matchup scope = SEVEN named hitters by DPO decision** — not a posted 1–9 card: Betts, Ohtani, Freeman, Muncy, Tucker, Pages, Edman. **Confirm the actual lineup before first pitch.** - **H2H is career and small: 8–86 PA per hitter.** Only **Freeman (86 PA)** is a real sample; the rest (8–25 PA) are **directional** and printed with their PA. Most last faced Nola in **April 2025** — they predate his 2026 shape. - **Season wOBA is FanGraphs-weighted** (the locked KPI); it reads ~.01 below the Statcast `woba_value` line. **xwOBA here means xwOBAcon** (mean estimated wOBA on balls in play) — a data-quality fix made this session; the pitch-level `get_stats.xwoba` column is contaminated and is **not** cited.

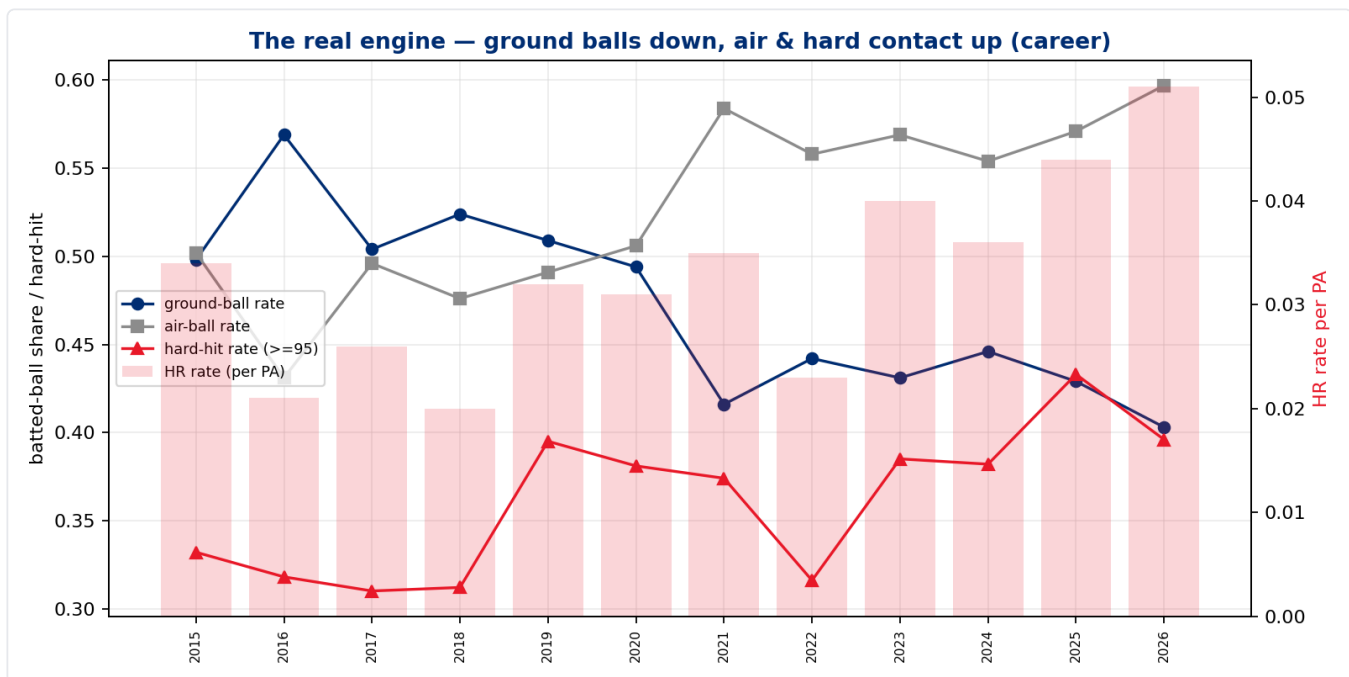
Bottom line

1. **The two-year slide is still sliding — but it isn't the stuff.** 2026 sits at **.358 wOBA / .509 SLG / 5.1% HR per PA**, all career worsts. Velocity is flat (4-seam 92.3, no decline) and the strikeout rate is steady (23.8%). This is a **contact-in-the-air** problem, not injury or arm strength.
2. **The left-handed problem, sharpened to one number.** Contact quality is **identical by side** — **xwOBAcon .382 vs LHB / .387 vs RHB**, whiff **28.3% / 26.8%**. The *entire* lefty gap is **the free pass: 10.7% walk rate vs LHB against 2.8% vs RHB**, on **58.8% first-pitch strikes vs 73.5%**. He nibbles lefties into hitters' counts and pays for it. **This lineup stands five left** (Ohtani, Freeman, Muncy, Tucker, and switch-hitter Edman).
3. **Don't blame the zone.** Edge rate **.370** (career norm .374), out-of-zone called strikes **.034** (a slow decade glide — 2025 was already .038, this is not a 2026 ABS cliff), chase-up rate **.311** (career-high area). The fix is sequencing and conviction, not the umpire.
4. **One real positive to build on: the changeup woke up.** It now misses bats at **26.9% vs LHB** (up from ~16% at UC8) and he has leaned in — **19.4% usage vs LHB, up to 21% staff-wide in July**. Paired with the **42.5%-whiff knuckle curve**, he finally has a two-pitch finish to lefties — *if he'll throw them in the zone*.
5. **The matchup: Betts is the danger; Freeman is the book; the rest are a manageable, familiar plan.** Mookie Betts has squared him (**.465, 2 HR / 23 PA**); Freeman is the volume history (**.307 / 86 PA**, patient). The plan is the one he executed at KC on **7/05 — 7 IP, 0 BB, 0 HR, 7 K**: get ahead of the lefties, finish with curve and changeup, keep the fastball out of the air.

The profile — a fourth straight step down, but the engine is contact

Season	GS	PA	wOBA	xwOBAAcon	K%	BB%	HR/PA	SLG
2022	32	809	.262	.343	29.0%	3.5%	2.3%	.346
2023	32	792	.303	.374	25.1%	5.7%	4.0%	.426
2024	33	822	.309	.371	23.8%	6.1%	3.6%	.420
2025	17	406	.344	.400	23.9%	6.9%	4.4%	.477
2026	20	453	.358	.384	23.8%	7.5%	5.1%	.509

The **.358** is the worst full-season wOBA of his career, and **SLG (.509)** and **HR rate (5.1%)** are career worsts alongside it. But read the rest of the row before you reach for an alarm: **the strikeouts haven't moved (23.8%)** and **the velocity is intact** — nothing in the arsenal has lost a tick. Even xwOBAAcon (.384) is a hair *below* 2025's .400, so 2026 is not a contact-quality cliff *beyond* where 2025 already was. What has grown is the **walk rate (7.5% — his highest since 2019)** and the **home-run rate (a career-worst 5.1%)** — free passes and balls in the air. This is a command-and-sequencing season, not a stuff-decline season.



Kept current — the three starts since the last report

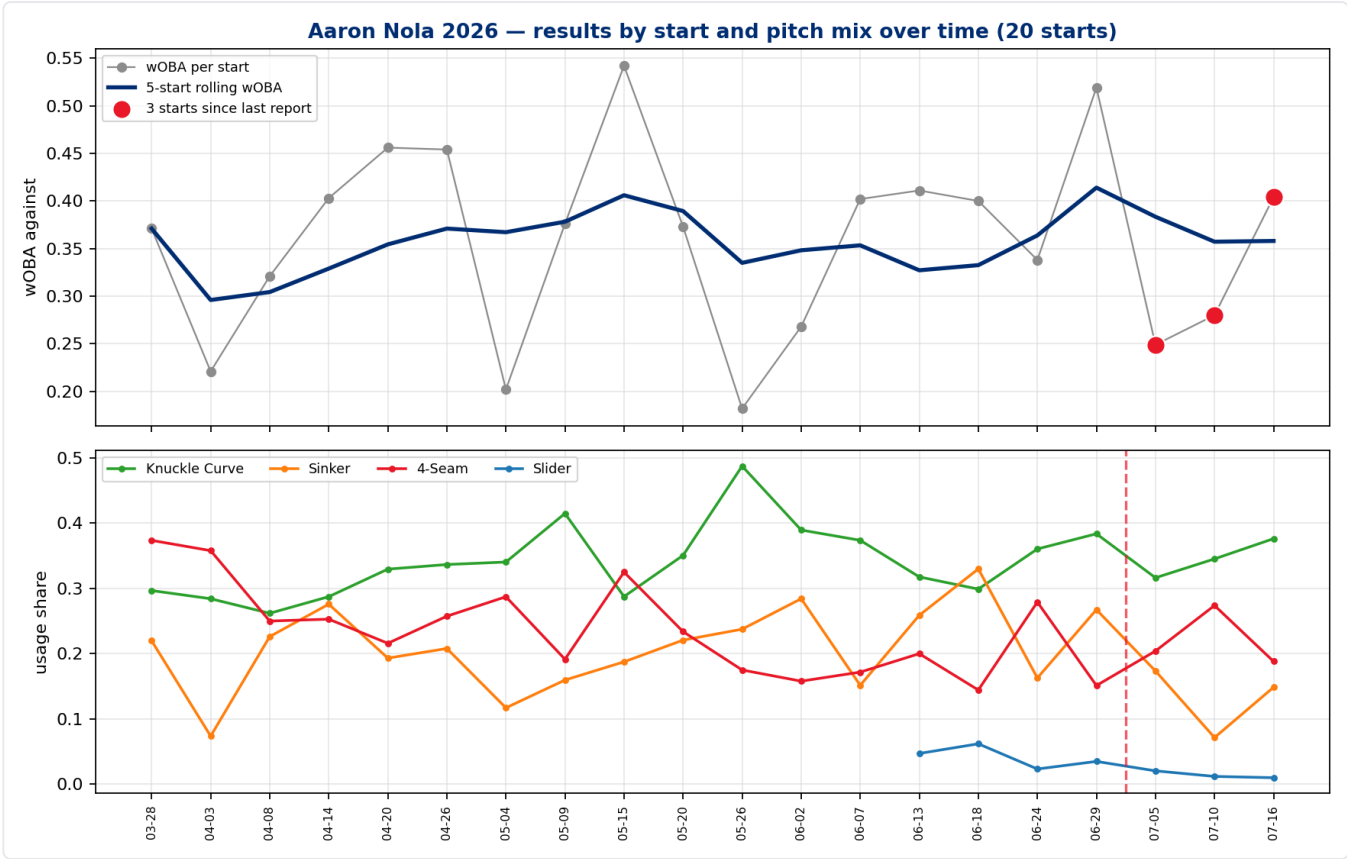
The advance file was last refreshed at dp_uc15 (through 7/04). Three starts have landed since:

Date	Opp	Venue	IP*	Pitches	PA	H	HR	BB	K	wOBA
2026-07-05	KC	road	7.0	98	28	7	0	0	7	.249
2026-07-10	DET	road	5.0	84	20	3	1	2	8	.280
2026-07-16	NYM	home	6.0	101	27	6	3	3	6	.404
Last-3 combined				283	75	16	4	5	21	.313

*IP computed from terminal events in the pitch log, not box scores.

The three-start line (.313 wOBA, .329 xwOBAcon, 75 PA) is a tick better than the season — and the **7/05 game is a proof of concept**: it's the exact KC lineup dp_uc15 flagged ("six of nine have homered off him"), and Nola answered with **7 innings, zero walks, zero homers, seven punchouts**. When he pounded the zone and finished with the breaker, the plan worked.

But be honest about the most recent look: on **7/16 he gave up three home runs** to the Mets — same failure mode, balls in the air — and walked three. The trend is encouraging; the problem is **not solved**. Two good starts and a three-homer clunker is a pitcher who is *capable* of the game plan, not one who has locked it in.

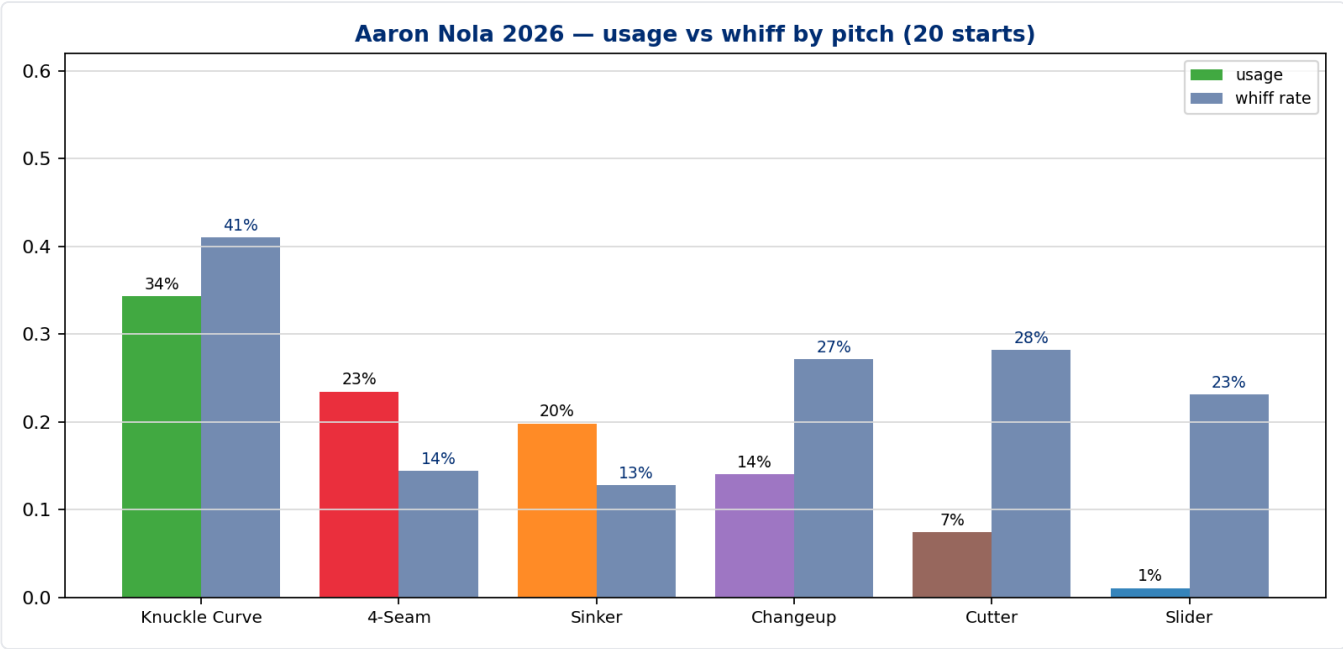
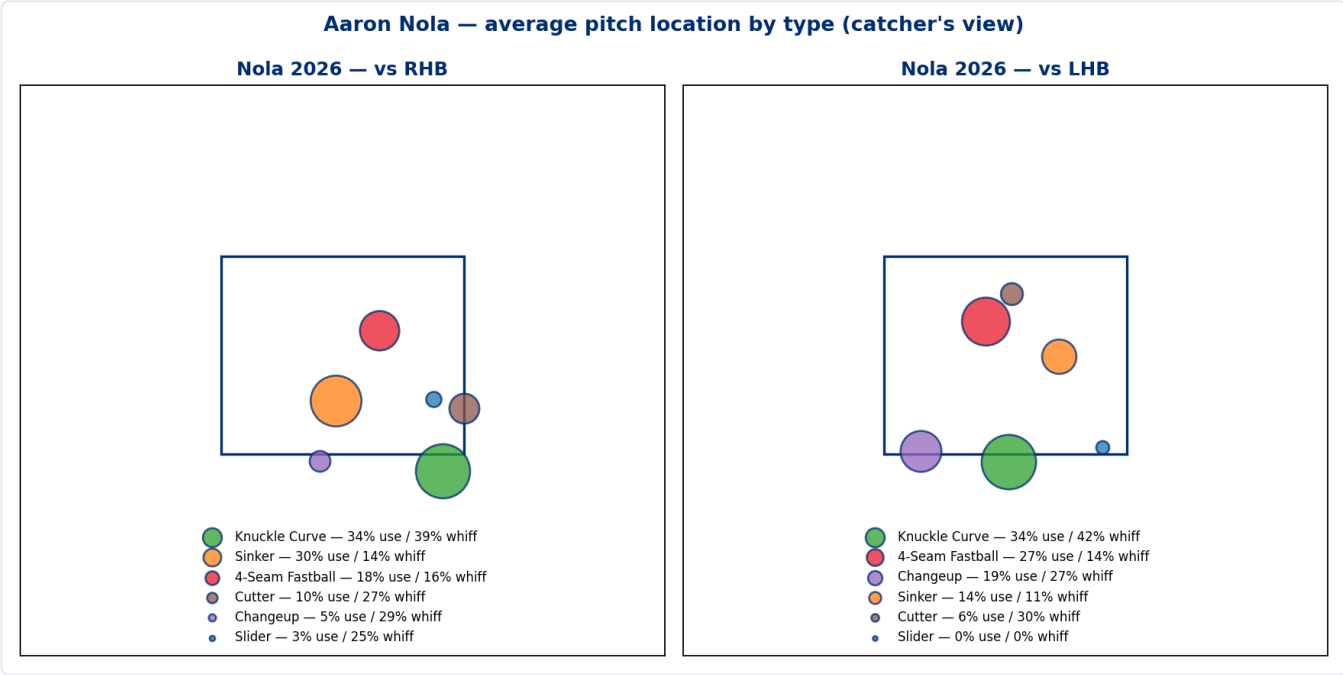


The arsenal — six pitches, one weapon, and a changeup that woke up

vs	Pitch	Usage	Velo	Whiff%	Role
LHB	Knuckle Curve	34.4%	78.1	42.5%	the putaway — below the zone, both sides
	4-Seam	26.7%	92.3	13.8%	get-ahead, up — the pitch that gets lifted
	Changeup	19.4%	85.6	26.9%	the improved weapon — fading away
	Sinker	13.7%	91.7	10.9%	back-door / in
	Cutter	5.6%	86.1	29.7%	in on hands — underused
RHB	Knuckle Curve	34.0%	78.4	38.7%	the putaway — below the zone
	Sinker	29.9%	91.5	14.1%	the anchor — glove-side, ground balls
	4-Seam	18.0%	92.1	15.9%	get-ahead, up
	Cutter	10.4%	86.0	26.8%	in on hands

vs	Pitch	Usage	Velo	Whiff%	Role
	Changeup	5.0%	85.3	28.6%	show
	Slider	2.7%	83.0	25.0%	RHB-only experiment (19 thrown all year)

The **knuckle curve is still the whole identity** — a third of the pitches to both sides and the only bat-misser that clears 38%. The 2026 wrinkle to righties is the **sinker at 30%**, pounded glove-side for grounders. And the news vs lefties is the **changeup**: at UC8 (June) it was his designated LHB weapon getting only ~16% whiff; across the full season it's up to **26.9%**, and his July usage spiked to 21%. He's earned the right to throw it more. The weak spot that remains is the **4-seam to lefties (13.8% whiff)** — the get-ahead fastball that, left up, becomes the air-ball damage.

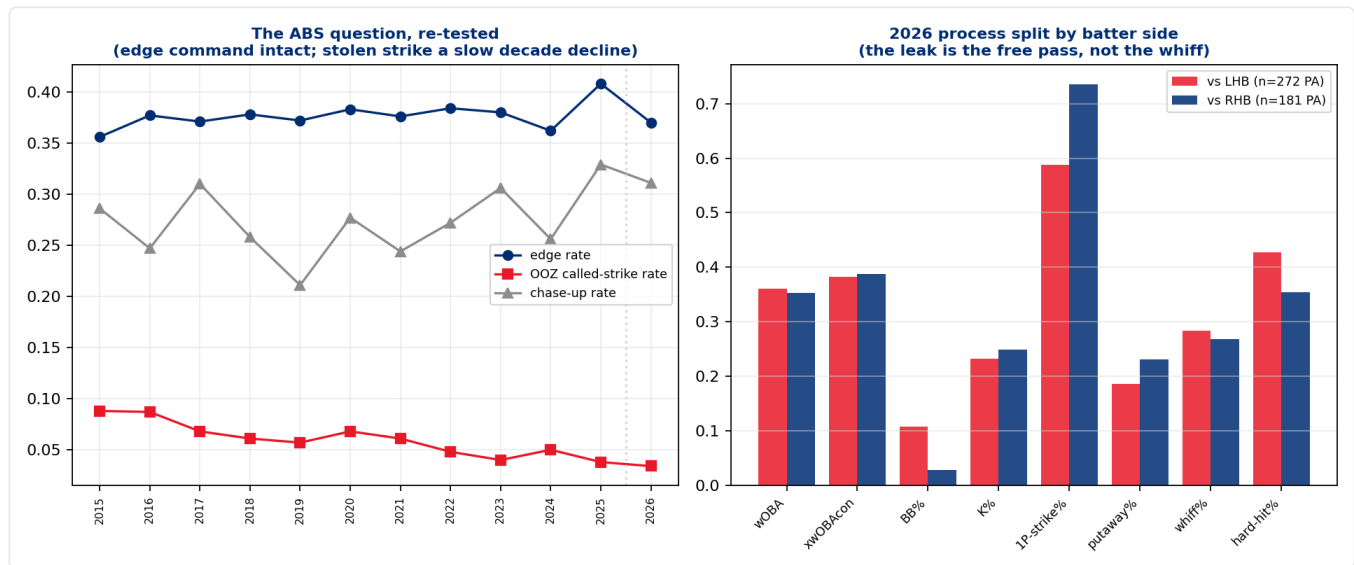


The left-handed problem — down to the indicator

This is the report. Same wOBA both sides; the *mechanism* is what separates them.

2026 process	vs LHB	vs RHB
Plate appearances	272	181
wOBA	.361	.353
xwOBAcon	.382	.387
Walk rate	10.7%	2.8%
Strikeout rate	23.2%	24.9%
First-pitch-strike rate	58.8%	73.5%
Put-away rate (2-strike)	18.6%	23.1%
Whiff rate	28.3%	26.8%
Chase rate	32.5%	32.9%
Hard-hit rate	42.7%	35.4%

He **misses bats at the same rate** to both sides (28% / 27%) and gives up **the same contact quality** (xwOBAcon .382 / .387). The only levers that move are the ones he controls: he throws a **first-pitch strike 15 points less often to lefties (58.8% vs 73.5%)**, so he **finishes them less (18.6% putaway vs 23.1%)**, so he **walks them nearly four times as often (10.7% vs 2.8%)**. The .361 lefty wOBA is a **sequencing tax he imposes on himself** — and tonight's lineup makes him pay it five times through the order.



The ABS question — asked again, same answer

UC8 tested whether the automated zone was the cause of the slump. Re-tested with data through 7/16, the answer holds:

- **Edge command is intact.** Edge rate .370 in 2026, within a whisker of the .374 career norm.

- The "stolen strike" is a slow decade decline, not a 2026 cliff. Out-of-zone called strikes fell from **~.088 (2015)** to **.034 (2026)** — but **2025 was already at .038**. An ABS-driven break would show a step-down *this* year; instead it's a nine-year glide.
- He still generates chase up. Chase-up rate **.311**, near his career high — hitters keep expanding above the zone.

The takeaway for the dugout is a *negative* one: don't spend a meeting on the zone. The two things the data flags are the **lefty free pass** and the **air-ball contact** — both self-correctable.

The contact-quality engine

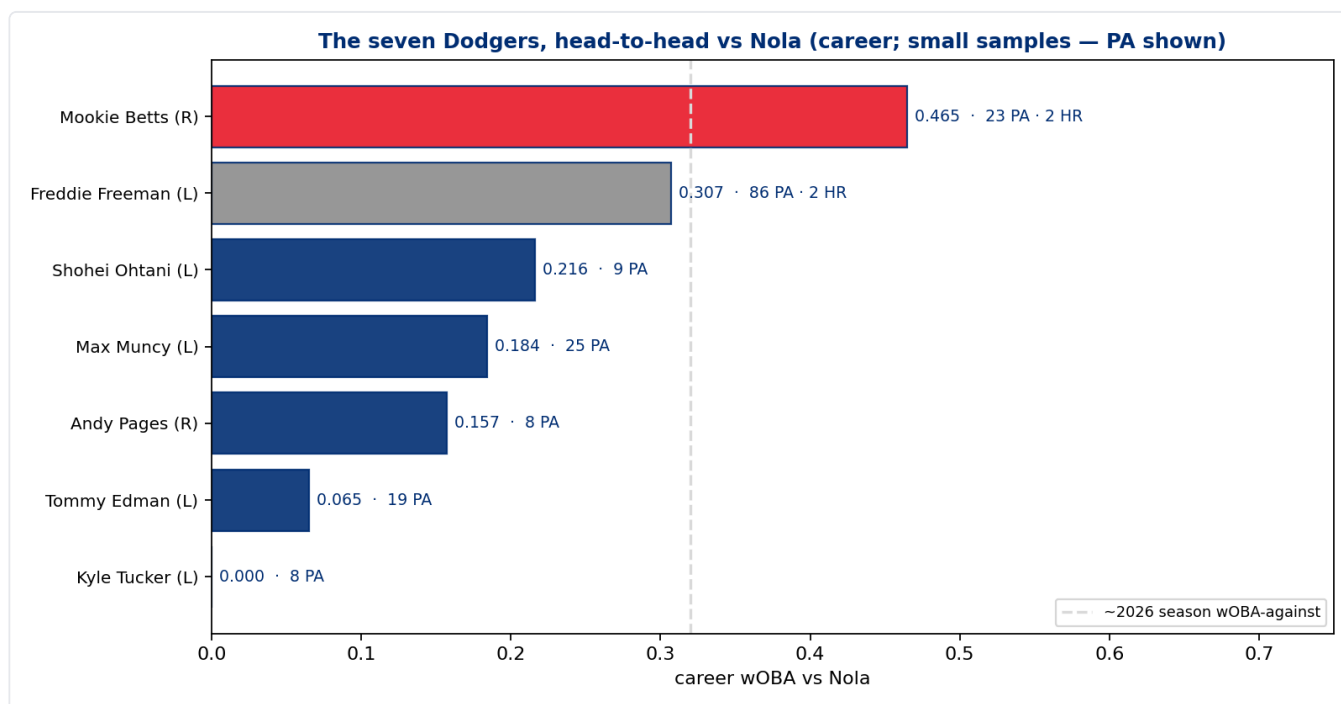
Batted-ball KPI (BIP)	2024	2025	2026	career-worst?
Ground-ball rate	44.6%	42.9%	40.3%	✓ lowest
Air-ball rate	55.4%	57.1%	59.7%	✓ highest
Hard-hit rate (≥95)	38.2%	43.3%	39.6%	— (2025 worse)
HR rate (per PA)	3.6%	4.4%	5.1%	✓ highest
xwOBAcon	.371	.400	.384	— (2025 worse)

Nola has always been a ground-ball-leaning contact manager. In 2026 **more balls are in the air (59.7%, a career high) and more are leaving the yard (5.1% HR, a career high)**. Hard-hit and xwOBAcon actually eased slightly off 2025 — so the incremental 2026 damage is specifically **the air-ball/home-run channel**. Keeping the ball down isn't a preference tonight; it's the entire run-prevention plan.

The Dodgers — the seven-hitter file

Career head-to-head from Nola's own log (name-parsed; **small samples — PA shown on every line**). Five of the seven stand left vs a RHP.

Hitter	Stands	PA	H	HR	BB	K	Whiff%	wOBA	xwOBAcon	Read
Mookie Betts	R	23	9	2	0	5	21%	.465	.555	DANGER — has squared him
Freddie Freeman	L	86	18	2	10	11	18%	.307	.397	WATCH — the real book, patient
Shohei Ohtani	L	9	1	0	1	3	44%	.216	.450	DANGER (talent + loud contact)
Max Muncy	L	25	4	0	1	11	30%	.184	.362	EXPLOIT — 11 K in 25 PA
Andy Pages	R	8	1	0	0	3	—	.157	.287	directional — thin book
Tommy Edman	L (S)	19	1	0	0	0	9%	.065	.240	EXPLOIT — weak contact
Kyle Tucker	L	8	0	0	0	1	—	.000	.230	directional — no real book



The plans (H2H-driven where the PA supports it, profile-driven where it doesn't):

- **Mookie Betts (R, 23 PA, .465, 2 HR).** The one Dodger who has genuinely hit him, and the contact is loud (.555 xwOBAcon). **Sinker glove-side at the knees, knuckle curve to the chase zone below — nothing middle, nothing he can extend on.** Pitch backward; don't let him sit in a hitter's count.
- **Freddie Freeman (L, 86 PA, .307, 10 BB).** The only large sample, and the archetype of Nola's leak — a patient lefty who **won't chase and will take the walk (10 in 86 PA)**. The wOBA says "handled," but **xwOBAcon .397 says the contact is loud when he does connect.** Pound the zone early; make him hit the curve or changeup down, not ball four.
- **Shohei Ohtani (L, 9 PA — directional).** The line is empty (3 K, .216) but the **.450 xwOBAcon over even 9 PA plus his talent = treat him as danger, full stop.** Never a fastball he can elevate; curve and changeup down, and **do not walk him into the Freeman/Muncy pocket.**
- **Max Muncy (L, 25 PA, .184, 11 K).** Nola has owned him — **11 strikeouts in 25 PA.** All-or-nothing lefty; **bury the knuckle curve, he'll chase it.** Don't groove a get-me-over cutter.
- **Tommy Edman (switch → L, 19 PA, .065, 9% whiff).** Handled — a contact bat Nola has kept off the barrel. Standard lefty plan; keep it down so he can't slap a fastball.
- **Andy Pages (R, 8 PA — directional) / Kyle Tucker (L, 8 PA — directional).** No real book on either. **Pages:** righty plan — sinker/curve, expand with two strikes. **Tucker:** left-handed plan — get ahead, curve and changeup away, keep the 4-seam out of the air (he's the highest-ceiling bat here without a track record vs Nola — respect the profile, not the 0-for-8).

The single attack rule

Get ahead of the five lefties, and finish them with the curve and the changeup — never a fastball they can lift. Everything Nola's leak costs him is a walk; everything this lineup does to him is in the air. Win the first pitch and keep the ball down, and the Dodgers are a manageable night.

Game-plan takeaways — by persona

1. **Nola — attack the zone first-pitch to lefties.** The **10.7% lefty walk rate** is the whole leak, and it starts at **58.8% first-pitch strikes** (73.5% to righties). First-pitch curve or sinker for a strike; save the chase pitches for two strikes. You don't need to be *fine* to this lineup — you need to be *ahead*.
2. **Catcher (Realmuto or Marchan) — call the two-pitch lefty finish.** Knuckle curve down (**42.5% whiff**) and changeup away (**26.9%, and warming**) are the putaway pair. **The two-strike pitch to a lefty is never a 4-seam middle** (13.8% whiff, and it's the air-ball pitch). With Marchan likely behind the plate and Stubbs out, keep the target below the zone with two strikes and make Nola commit to the breaker.
3. **Pitching coach / analyst — reinforce the changeup, and script the third time through.** The changeup-vs-LHB jump (16% → 27% whiff) is real; keep feeding it. And the damage this year clusters as the lineup turns over — his four .40+ wOBA starts in June and the **7/16 three-homer game** all came late. Have the hook conversation ready for the Betts/Ohtani/Freeman pocket the third time.
4. **Manager — leash by matchup, not pitch count.** ~95–100 pitches is the range, but the trigger is the **third pass through the lefty top**, not a round number. The bullpen lever tonight is that lefty core — have a left-hander warm for the **Ohtani/Freeman/Muncy** stretch if Nola's first-pitch-strike rate to them is sagging.
5. **Nola / catcher — pick your spots to pitch backward.** **Betts** is the only Dodger who's beaten him and **Ohtani** is the only other with a loud contact-quality signal on a thin sample. Those two get the pitch-backward treatment; **everyone else is get-ahead-and-expand**.
6. **Analyst / advance desk — confirm the card and refresh if needed.** This file is **seven named hitters, not a posted 1–9**. Confirm the actual lineup before first pitch, and re-run `dp_uc25_nola_vs_dodgers.py` if a 21st start lands or the lineup firms up.

Candid data-window & freshness caveats

- **Pre-game projection.** Tonight's game is not — and cannot be — in any cache. Nothing here reflects in-game data.
- **Matchup = 7 named hitters (DPO scope),** not a confirmed 1–9. The L/R math (5 lefties) depends on the actual card; confirm it.
- **H2H is career and small (8–86 PA)** and reconstructed from Nola's own log via des-parsed batter ids. **Only Freeman (86 PA) is a real sample;** the rest are directional. Most last faced Nola in **April 2025** and predate his 2026 pitch shape. **Betts .465/23 PA** and **Ohtani .450 xwOBAcon/9 PA** are flags, not forecasts.
- **Season wOBA is FanGraphs-weighted** (the locked KPI), ~.01 under the Statcast `woba_value` line; it **supersedes dp_uc15's .377** (that was an earlier cache, closer to the Statcast side). **xwOBA = xwOBAcon on balls in play** — a data-quality correction made this session, because the locked `get_stats.xwoba` pitch-level column is contaminated by non-BIP rows and is not fit to cite.
- **IP on game lines is computed** from terminal events in the pitch log, not official box scores (marked with an asterisk); pitch counts and PA-level results are exact.
- **Results vs process, said plainly:** the last-3 **.313 wOBA** sits on a **.329 xwOBAcon** — real recent improvement — but the **7/16 three-homer start** says don't declare victory. The lefty wOBA gap, by contrast, is **process (walks), not contact** — which is exactly why it's fixable tonight.
- **Artifact pointers:** build script `dp_uc25_nola_vs_dodgers.py`; receipts `out/dp_uc25_*.csv / .png`; governance trail `dp_uc25_nola_vs_dodgers_use_case_spec.md`; independent verification `dp_uc25_verification.py`.

Source: governed Phillies Pitching data product, UC#26 (`uc-pps-021`). Nola pitcher-side from `data/phillies/phils_2015..2026.parquet` (regular season, `pitcher==605400`), fresh through 2026-07-16. Dodgers head-to-head from the same log filtered to the seven named hitters (des-parsed ids). Locked KPIs inherited verbatim from the

UC8 → UC11 → UC15 line; edge rate / OZ called-strike rate / AIR-GB rate inherited from UC8. Pattern lineage UC3 → UC6 → UC8 → UC11 → UC15 → UC26.